his Buddhism. The prehistoric paintings show animals, including monkeys, and hunters. They are in the same line of rock shelters, halfway up a hill, in which Ashoka's message is engraved. Spread across the hillside are a large number of stupas made of dressed stones, some with platforms, the diameters ranging from 2 to 76 metres. Alongside are monastic cells within rubble enclosures. A stunning architectural remnant from Panguraria is a stone umbrella and an umbrella shaft that supported it, which may well be Mauryan. Engraved on the shaft is an inscription which records that the umbrella is the gift of 'bhikshuni' (nun) Sagharakhita; it was caused to be made by Pusa, Dhamarakhita, and Araha, the 'amtevasinis' of Koramika.[47] 'Amtevasinis' literally means those living on the border, although it was usually used to describe pupils.

This juxtaposition of painted rock shelters and Buddhist remains is a very widespread feature of large parts of Central India. Not far from Panguraria is Talpura, where again rock shelters show prehistoric and historic paintings, while above stand two stone stupas on a large platform. The famous Buddhist centre of Sanchi, whose great stupa built by Ashoka we will discuss later, stands on a hill where a line of rock shelters can still be seen along an old road leading to Vidisha. The shelters bear prehistoric and historic representations—animals, men, an antler mask, horse and elephant riders. The pre-existing sacredness of these places from prehistoric time suggests a continuity into historic time of a new variant of the same basic religious impulse, the shape now being Buddhism. Monastic groups, adherents of the later faith, sometimes chose to inhabit these shelters in unconscious or deliberate acknowledgement of some sort of emotional kinship with those who had gone before.

This would have been true for Panguraria as much as for other such spots. What makes Panguraria both different and distinctive is that it is the only place within this region where Ashoka's rescript was recorded on the stone walls of a rock shelter.[48] Known as the Saru-Maru cave (or 'gufa'),